Make the arepas: Preheat the oven to 350°F. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper.

Divide the arepa dough into 8 equal portions. Lightly grease your palms with oil. Flatten each dough ball into a disc about 4 inches across and ⅓ inch thick.

Heat a large cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. Add a little oil and swirl to coat. Working in batches, add the arepas in a single layer so there's a bit of space between them. Cook for about 5 minutes, or until deep golden brown on the bottom (a few blackened spots are okay). You're looking to form a crust.

Flip and cook for about 5 minutes longer, or until the second sides are also browned.

Place on the lined baking sheet and transfer to the oven.

Bake for 15 to 18 minutes, until slightly puffed and a little more golden brown in color. Let cool for 5 to 10 minutes before cutting or splitting the arepas open.

When ready to assemble, divide the pulled bison meat evenly among the arepas, either spooning it on top or stuffing it inside the split ones. Serve with more sauce.

AREPAS

1¼ pounds Arepa Dough (page 32) or Easy Arepa Dough (recipe follows)
Avocado oil, for forming and cooking the arepas

Note: *To cook the meat in a pressure cooker, combine the seasoned roast with ⅔ cup water and cook on high for 2 hours. Let the pressure release naturally, then pull the meat. Add the 1½ cups barbecue sauce to the meat and keep the pot on warm for at least 30 minutes, or until you're ready to serve with the arepas.*

EASY AREPA DOUGH

makes 8 arepas

You can make a simpler arepa dough using arepa flour, which is a precooked cornmeal (not nixtamalized corn) that is sold specifically for arepas.

2½ cups warm water
1¼ teaspoons fine sea salt
2 cups arepa flour

To make 1¾ pounds of dough, in a large bowl, whisk together the warm water and salt until the salt dissolves. Gradually add the arepa flour, vigorously mixing by hand. The mixture will start out thin and quickly become a soft, thick dough when all the flour is added.

Knead in the bowl for about 2 minutes, until there are only a few very small lumps. The dough should be moist and tacky but not sticky. (If the dough feels sticky, add more of the arepa flour a tablespoon at a time, mixing well after each addition. If the edges crack, the dough is too dry. Add more water a tablespoon at a time to adjust texture.)

Cover the bowl tightly with a lid or plastic wrap to rest and hydrate for at least 10 minutes and up to 2 hours.

tortilla press to flatten each [illegible] a disc about ¼ inch thick and about 3½ inches wide.

Scoop about 1½ tablespoons of the squash filling into the center of each disc. Fold the dough over the filling, pressing the edges to seal. Set the tlacoyo seam-side up and gently press to flatten into a football shape or use a rolling pin. (There will be some squash filling left over; hold on to it.) Cover the tlacoyos with a clean towel as you fill and shape each one.

spots on the second sides.

Spread a little more of the squash filling on top of the tlacoyos and serve hot, topped with the pico de gallo and pickled habaneros (if using). Garnish with the toasted squash seeds and serve.

[illegible] tablespoon avocado or sunflower oil, plus more for the pan
Pickled Habanero Chiles (optional; recipe below), for serving

CHILES HABANEROS EN VINAGRE

Pickled Habanero Chiles

makes 1 pint

Habanero chiles are especially popular in Southern Mexico. I love their sweet, fruity, fiery heat with so many dishes. I recommend wearing gloves when handling habaneros.

- 5 habanero chiles
- 2 tablespoons sunflower oil
- ¼ cup thinly sliced red onion
- ¼ cup thinly sliced carrot rounds
- 2 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
- 2 allspice berries
- 1 bay leaf
- ½ teaspoon fine sea salt
- ¾ cup cider vinegar
- ¼ cup plus 2 tablespoons agave syrup

While wearing gloves, cut off the stems from the habaneros. Remove the seeds and interior ribs for a milder pickle. (It will still be very spicy.) Cut the chiles crosswise into rings ¼ inch thick.

In a nonreactive medium saucepan, heat the oil over medium heat. Add the chiles, onion, carrot, garlic, allspice, and bay leaf. Stir to coat and cook for about 3 minutes, or until everything is fragrant and the vegetables start to soften.

Turn off the heat and stir in the salt, ¾ cup water, the vinegar, and agave syrup. Let cool to room temperature. Ladle everything into a jar, close the jar, and refrigerate for at least 24 hours before using. The pickled chiles can be refrigerated for up to 2 weeks.

CORN TORTILLAS

makes sixteen 6-inch tortillas

At our Indigenous Food Lab, you'll often see griddles lined with tortillas puffed up like balloons. The puff happens after a third flip, during the last few seconds of cooking, when a pocket of steam presses apart the outer edges of the tortilla. It's a sign that the masa was perfectly ground, hydrated, pressed, and seared on a very hot pan, and the tortilla is thoroughly cooked on the inside.

The puff can take practice to achieve but isn't crucial to a delicious tortilla. Whether they perfectly puff or not, these tortillas will still taste so much better than store-bought tortillas that sit on the shelves for weeks at a time.

If you decide you enjoy making tortillas, I recommend getting a tortilla press to help you create consistent rounds. But you can also press them with a pie plate or roll them out with a rolling pin.

1 pound Fresh Masa (page 28) or use masa harina (see chart, page 27)

Knead the masa in a bowl to assess the texture. For soft tortillas, you want the dough to feel moist but not sticky. If it feels a bit dry, add 1 teaspoon water and knead for about 30 seconds, repeating until you have the right consistency.

To test the dough, roll the masa into a ball, the size of a Ping-Pong ball, then flatten into a ½-inch-thick round. If the edge is smooth, the dough is ready. If it cracks, knead in more water, 1 teaspoon at a time. If the dough sticks to your hands, you'll want to add masa harina or just let the dough stand for 10 minutes to allow it to dry a bit and then test again.

Divide the dough into 16 equal portions and roll into balls the size of Ping-Pong balls. Heat a well-seasoned comal, griddle, or cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat for 2 minutes. (You're aiming for the surface to reach at least 400°F.)

Set a piece of plastic wrap or parchment paper on the bottom of a tortilla press or a work surface. Place a ball of the dough on top. Set a piece of plastic wrap or parchment paper on top of the dough. Press or roll the dough into a 1/16-inch-thick tortilla.

Uncover, peel the tortilla off the wrap, and transfer to the griddle. Sear for 20 to 30 seconds, until dry on the bottom with a little bit of blistering in spots. Flip and cook for another 20 to 30 seconds. Flip one last time, pressing the tortilla in spots with a spatula, and cook for 10 to 20 seconds, looking for that magical tortilla puff. (If it doesn't puff, it's okay.)

Transfer to a clean kitchen towel and cover to keep warm as you press and cook the remaining tortillas.

You can place tortillas between layers of parchment paper and freeze in an airtight container for up to 1 month.

ON MASA HARINA

Masa harina allows you to make masa more easily at home. The flour, made from nixtamalized, dehydrated, and ground corn, lets you just add water. For many years, Maseca was the only widely available brand of masa harina, but you can now find better-quality versions online and at some markets.

Masienda (masienda.com), for example, makes masa harina from four different colors of corn, all sourced from heirloom corn grown in Mexico. Bob's Red Mill makes their masa harina from organic yellow corn and King Arthur Flour uses organic white corn.

You can make any of the recipes in the book that call for fresh masa using masa harina. Below are some rough equivalencies. Know that when you use masa harina, you might often end up with a little extra than what's called for in the recipe, but that's okay.

FRESH MASA (by WEIGHT)	MASA HARINA	FINE SEA SALT	WARM WATER
8 ounces	1 cup	pinch	¾ cup
1 pound	1¾ cups	¼ teaspoon	1⅓ cups
1½ pounds	2½ cups	⅜ teaspoon	2 scant cups
2 pounds	3½ cups	½ teaspoon	2⅔ cups

THE METHOD In a bowl, stir together the masa harina and salt, then add the warm water. Knead to form a soft dough, making sure no dry spots remain. Cover and let stand for 20 minutes to 1 hour to allow the flour to fully hydrate before using the masa.

You might need to add a little more water or masa harina to achieve the proper texture, which will depend on the recipe.